Name: _____ Date: _____

The Rise and Fall of the Assyrian Empire

Key Terms
Siege — a military tactic where an army surrounds a city to force it to surrender.
Tribute — money or goods paid by conquered people to a stronger ruler.

Around 850 B.C., a group of people called the Assyrians began to build a massive empire. They came from the northern part of Mesopotamia. Unlike some regions protected by mountains or deserts, the Assyrian homeland was flat and exposed. This made it very easy for outsiders to attack. Because they were constantly being invaded, the Assyrians developed a warlike culture to survive. They believed that military strength was the only way to keep their people safe.



Assyrian soldiers used advanced iron weapons.

To expand their power, the Assyrians built a "military machine" that was the most advanced of its time. They were among the first to use iron technology on a large scale. Their soldiers wore metal-scaled armor and copper helmets. They carried iron-tipped spears and sharp iron swords. Because iron was much stronger than the bronze used by other groups, the Assyrians easily overwhelmed their enemies.



Battering rams were used to break city gates.

The Assyrians were experts at taking over walled cities. They used engineers to build floating bridges called pontoons to cross deep rivers. When they reached a city, they used "sappers"—soldiers who dug tunnels under the city walls to make them crumble. At the same time, they used massive iron-tipped battering rams to smash through heavy wooden gates. Once they broke inside, the Assyrians were known for being very cruel. They often killed or enslaved the people they defeated. To stop future rebellions, they forced thousands of captives to move to distant parts of the empire.

Governing a Giant Empire

By 650 B.C., the Assyrian Empire stretched from the Tigris River all the way to Egypt. To manage such a huge area, the kings created a new system of government. They divided the land into provinces. Each province had a local governor who reported directly to the central authority (the king). This became a model for many future governments. The kings also collected taxes and tribute from the people they ruled. This wealth helped pay for grand building projects, like the capital city of Nineveh.



Ashurbanipal's library held 20,000 clay tablets.

Nineveh was the largest city of its time, surrounded by great walls. It wasn't just a place for war; it was also a center of culture. King Ashurbanipal built one of the ancient world's largest libraries there. He collected over 20,000 clay tablets, including the famous *Epic of Gilgamesh*. This library was very organized, with tablets sorted into different rooms by subject, much like a modern library.

The Fall of Assyria and the Rise of Babylon



The Hanging Gardens were one of the Seven Wonders.

Despite their power, the Assyrian Empire did not last. They had spread their army too thin by trying to control too much land. Also, their cruelty made them many enemies. In 612 B.C., two groups called the Medes and the Chaldeans joined forces. They attacked Nineveh and burned it to the ground. Most people in the region were happy to see the Assyrians defeated.

The Chaldeans took control and made Babylon their new capital. A king named Nebuchadnezzar restored the city to its former glory. He is famous for building the Hanging Gardens of Babylon, which were built on high terraces to please his wife. He also built massive walls around the city and a giant ziggurat that was 300 feet tall. While the Chaldean Empire was short-lived, their astronomers made important discoveries about the solar system that we still study today.

Check Your Understanding

1. How did the geography of the Assyrian homeland influence their military behavior?

2. Why was iron technology a major advantage for the Assyrian army?

Circle the correct answer.

A) Iron was stronger and more durable than the bronze weapons used by others.
B) Iron weapons were cheaper to make than wooden spears.
C) Iron was lighter and allowed soldiers to run much faster.

3. Describe two specific tactics the Assyrians used to capture walled cities.

4. Explain why the Assyrian Empire eventually collapsed.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Environment, Belief, and Survival

The Big Idea

Historians study how the **environment** (the land and climate) shapes a group's **beliefs** (what they value) and their **systems** (how they organize their government). Use your reading about the Assyrians to complete this analysis.

Part 1: The Assyrian Adaptation

Complete the table below to show how the Assyrians adapted to their environment in Mesopotamia.

Category	Evidence from the Text
Physical Environment Describe the Assyrian homeland.	
Belief System How did they view military strength?	
Administrative Systems How did they control their land?	

Part 2: Whiteboard Mind Map Planning

You will soon create a Mind Map on the classroom whiteboard. Use these prompts to plan your ideas. Focus on the connection between **geography** and **innovation**.

1. The Assyrian homeland was flat and exposed, leaving them open to attacks from the mountains. How did this specific geographic problem lead to the invention of the "military machine" (iron weapons, sappers, and battering rams)?

2. The Assyrians used engineers to build **pontoons** to cross deep rivers. Why was this technology necessary for an empire located in the Fertile Crescent?

3. List three keywords or symbols you will include in your Mind Map to represent the connection between the land and Assyrian survival.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Empire Building Vocabulary

Directions: Match each term or name from our study of the Assyrian and Chaldean Empires to its correct description. Draw a line to connect the pairs.

Term	Definition
Sennacherib	The Assyrian capital city along the Tigris River, famous for its massive walls and great library.
Nineveh	The Assyrian king who established the capital at Nineveh and bragged about destroying 89 cities.
Ashurbanipal	The last mighty Assyrian king who collected more than 20,000 clay tablets for his library.
Medes	One of the two groups that joined forces in 612 B.C. to burn Nineveh and defeat the Assyrians.
Chaldeans	The group that made Babylon their capital and became the center of a new empire after the Assyrians.
Nebuchadnezzar	The Chaldean king who restored Babylon and built the famous Hanging Gardens.
Provinces	Smaller areas that an empire is divided into, each managed by a local governor.
Tribute	Money or goods paid by conquered people to a stronger power to show they are under its control.

Fill in the Blanks

Use the words from the word bank to complete the sentences below about the rise and fall of these empires.

Word Bank

Sennacherib	Nineveh	Ashurbanipal
Chaldeans	Nebuchadnezzar	Provinces
Tribute		

1. To manage their vast empire, the Assyrians divided their land into _____, which were governed by local officials who reported to the king.

2. Conquered people were forced to pay _____ to the Assyrian treasury; if they refused, their cities were destroyed.

3. King _____ was a fierce warrior who destroyed Babylon, but he also built the great city of _____.

4. The library at Nineveh was created by King _____, who organized and cataloged thousands of clay tablets.

5. After the Assyrian Empire fell, the _____ took control of the region and made Babylon their capital.

6. The city of Babylon was restored to its former glory by King _____, who built thick walls and a 300-foot tall ziggurat.

Remember

The Assyrian administrative model—using local governors to report to a central authority—became the standard way for future empires to manage large amounts of land.

Name: _____ Date: _____

Answer Key

Activity 2: Environment, Belief, and Survival

Part 1: The Assyrian Adaptation

- **Physical Environment:** The Assyrian homeland was located in northern Mesopotamia. The land was flat and exposed, making it easy for invaders from the nearby mountains to attack.
- **Belief System:** The Assyrians glorified military strength. They developed warlike behavior as a response to constant invasions, believing that a powerful military machine was necessary for survival.
- **Administrative Systems:** They divided conquered lands into provinces governed by local officials who reported to a central authority. They also collected taxes and tribute from these regions to fund the empire.

Part 2: Whiteboard Mind Map Planning

1. **Geography and Innovation:** Because the flat land offered no natural defenses, the Assyrians innovated to become the attackers rather than the victims. They developed iron-tipped battering rams to break gates and used sappers to dig under walls, turning their geographic vulnerability into a reason for superior siege technology.
2. **Pontoons:** Since the Fertile Crescent is defined by the Tigris and Euphrates rivers, the Assyrian army frequently encountered deep water. Pontoons allowed their massive army to maintain mobility and speed across the region.
3. **Keywords/Symbols:** (Sample answers) Iron spears, Nineveh Library, Battering rams, Tigris River, Clay tablets.

Activity 3: Empire Building Vocabulary

Matching

- **Nineveh** → The Assyrian capital city along the Tigris River, famous for its massive walls and great library.
- **Sennacherib** → The Assyrian king who established the capital at Nineveh and bragged about destroying 89 cities.
- **Ashurbanipal** → The last mighty Assyrian king who collected more than 20,000 clay tablets for his library.
- **Medes** → One of the two groups that joined forces in 612 B.C. to burn Nineveh and defeat the Assyrians.
- **Chaldeans** → The group that made Babylon their capital and became the center of a new empire after the Assyrians.
- **Nebuchadnezzar** → The Chaldean king who restored Babylon and built the famous Hanging Gardens.
- **Provinces** → Smaller areas that an empire is divided into, each managed by a local governor.
- **Tribute** → Money or goods paid by conquered people to a stronger power to show they are under its control.

Fill in the Blanks

1. **Provinces** (Rationale: The text defines provinces as the administrative units governed by local officials reporting to the king.)
2. **Tribute** (Rationale: This was the specific term for payments made to the treasury; refusal resulted in destruction.)
3. **Sennacherib; Nineveh** (Rationale: Sennacherib is noted for both the destruction of Babylon and the establishment of Nineveh.)
4. **Ashurbanipal** (Rationale: He is specifically credited with the collection and cataloging of the 20,000 tablets.)
5. **Chaldeans** (Rationale: The Chaldeans led the rebirth of Babylon after the fall of Nineveh.)
6. **Nebuchadnezzar** (Rationale: He is the Chaldean king credited with the restoration of the city and the great ziggurat.)